Afghan leadership confirms this. For Ahmad Wali Massoud, the younger brother of Ahmad Shah Massoud, India's shift in stance after the 2001 Bonn Conference was 'so immediate, so quick' that 'people in the Resistance [UF] did not take much notice of what happened.'[166] Abdullah also testifies to this shift in India's approach, and wanted India not to focus all its political energy on Karzai.[167] All the three drivers of India's Afghanistan policy—external political environment, India's desire to strike balance between Afghanistan and Pakistan, and domestic Afghan political equations—were aligned in a manner that the appeal of the conciliators went up in India after Bonn. With the US in the picture, Russia and Iran's salience had gone down (relative to the 1990s) in Afghanistan (for India). Even though Zamir Kabulov had little confidence in the West's plans for Afghanistan, Moscow did not influence the course of events after 9/11.[168] China too maintained a low profile and was blamed for free riding on the US security umbrella.

After years of disconnect, the *Kabuliwallah* bond with the Pashtuns started to form a strong undercurrent in Indian policy circles once again. A majority of India's diplomatic and security officials interviewed for this book evoked this historical bond. Having opened consulates in Kandahar, Jalalabad, Mazar-e-Sharif, and Herat, in addition to its embassy in Kabul, India began developing an independent understanding of intra-Pashtun political and tribal dynamics. Further reflecting cultural aspects to India's decision-making, G. Parthasarthy, former Indian ambassador to Pakistan, stated that given modern Afghanistan's political and social history, India could not have sent a Sikh regiment (or any other Indian regiment) to run a Provincial Reconstruction Team (PRT) in Pashtun-dominated areas of Afghanistan.[169] As conciliators advocated throughout the 1990s, India was slowly coming to terms with engaging everyone on the Afghan political landscape. Sood, who was the architect of India's covert infrastructure in Afghanistan (the most potent covert investments India made in Afghanistan were immediately after the Bonn conference), clearly states that historical bonds played an important role in the heyday of the war on terror. 'By 2002–03 we started saying that we can't keep the Pashtuns out forever. They constitute the single largest [ethnic] group, and are the closest to the [Pakistan] border. You can't deal with Balochistan unless you deal with the Pashtuns. And